Zeporah Design System v1 and Canonical MVP Screen Map v1

Purpose

This document defines the first practical product design system and the canonical MVP screen inventory for Zeporah. It is meant to be used as a working product artifact for design, prototyping, testing, and eventual implementation planning.

The goal is not to create a large abstract design library. The goal is to create a lean, opinionated, reusable system that keeps Zeporah calm, trustworthy, and coherent as the product grows from a concept prototype into a real MVP.

Product intent

Zeporah should feel like a steady, compassionate coordination space for people navigating emotionally heavy logistical work. The product should help users move forward without pressure, understand what is private versus shared, and safely involve other people only when they choose.

The product should not feel like a generic productivity app, a hospital portal, a legal system, or a social feed. It should feel supportive, quiet, dignified, and clear.

Brand principles

Quiet strength

The interface should feel stable and composed. It should never look frantic, loud, hyper-optimized, or gamified.

Guided clarity

The system should help users understand what matters now, what can wait, and what is already handled. Guidance should reduce ambiguity without becoming controlling.

Explicit trust

The product must make privacy and sharing boundaries visible at all times. Users should never have to guess who can see what.

Emotional gentleness

The interface should acknowledge that users may be overwhelmed, interrupted, distracted, or emotionally exhausted. Re-entry, reminders, and confirmations should lower pressure.

Practical usefulness

Zeporah still needs to help people complete real work. Warmth without operational clarity will not be enough.

Experience attributes

The UI and interaction model should consistently feel:

- Calm.
- Warm but restrained.
- Private.
- Legible.
- Non-judgmental.
- Reassuring.
- Capable.
- Human, but not sentimental.

It should avoid feeling:

- Corporate.
- Cold.
- Medicalized.
- Bureaucratic.
- Cheerfully generic.
- Overdesigned.
- Aggressive.
- Consumer-growth optimized.

Foundations

Typography

Type personality

Typography should balance dignity and usability. Headings should feel thoughtful and grounded, while body text should remain highly readable and emotionally neutral.

Recommended pairing

- Display or title font: a refined serif with warmth and structure.
- Body and UI font: a clean sans-serif with strong legibility.

Working pairing used in prototype direction:

- Display: Fraunces or an equivalent restrained editorial serif.
- Body: Inter or an equivalent neutral sans-serif.

Usage rules

- Use the serif family for page titles, hero moments, and select section headers.
- Use the sans-serif family for all body text, labels, form fields, helper text, buttons, navigation, and metadata.
- Avoid too many weight changes. Prefer structure through spacing and grouping rather than decorative typography.
- Do not use condensed, techno, playful, or heavily branded novelty fonts.

Suggested scale

- Page title: 40 to 56 px.
- Section heading: 24 to 32 px.
- Card title: 18 to 22 px.
- Body copy: 16 px.
- Secondary copy: 14 px.
- Labels and metadata: 12 px minimum.

Color system

Color philosophy

The palette should feel soft, grounded, and credible. Neutrals should carry most of the UI. Accent color should be used for focus, trust, and actions rather than decoration.

Core palette direction

- Background: warm off-white or parchment neutrals.
- Surface: soft ivory and sand layers.
- Primary: deep muted teal or grounded blue-green.
- Supporting warm accent: muted clay, cedar, or warm brown.
- Success: soft moss or muted green.
- Warning: pale ochre or warm amber.
- Sensitive or danger state: muted rose or restrained red-brown.

Color rules

- The interface should be mostly neutral.
- Accent colors should signal meaning, not just style.
- Privacy and trust states need semantic consistency across every flow.
- Avoid bright gradients, electric blues, neon greens, and startup-style purple palettes.

Spacing

Spacing should do a large part of the emotional work. Dense layouts will make the product feel stressful.

Rules:

- Favor generous vertical spacing between sections.
- Use comfortable padding inside cards, modals, and list rows.
- Keep forms breathable.
- Avoid cluttered dashboards and overcompressed tables.

Suggested scale:

- Tight inset: 8 px.
- Standard control spacing: 12 to 16 px.
- Card padding: 16 to 24 px.
- Section spacing: 24 to 40 px.
- Major page spacing: 40 to 64 px.

Radius and shape

The interface should feel soft but not bubbly.

Rules:

- Use medium to large radius on cards, panels, and modal containers.

- Use smaller radius for inputs and compact controls.
- Avoid sharp corners except for very subtle dividers or utility structures.
- Avoid exaggerated rounding that makes the product feel juvenile or overly consumerized.

Elevation and borders

Depth should be subtle.

Rules:

- Prefer soft shadows and light tonal separation.
- Use thin neutral borders for structure.
- Use stronger elevation only for modals, focused surfaces, or critical review steps.
- Do not use harsh black shadows or shiny effects.

Iconography

The icon system should be simple, restrained, and functional.

Rules:

- Use line-based icons or very lightly filled icons.
- Use icons primarily for navigation, state support, and small comprehension aids.
- Do not let icons dominate cards or create a template-like SaaS appearance.
- Avoid decorative icon circles unless there is a clear semantic reason.

Motion and transitions

Motion should preserve context and reduce friction.

Rules:

- Prefer fades, slides, and soft upward transitions.
- Use modal overlays for sensitive reviews and approvals.
- Preserve user context when moving between task, helper, support, and document flows.
- Avoid springy, flashy, or playful animation.
- Respect reduced-motion preferences.

Semantic state model

This is one of the most important parts of the product system.

Zeporah needs a stable set of trust and visibility states that can be recognized quickly across tasks, support, helper collaboration, and documents.

Required semantic states

- Private: visible only to the primary user.
- Shared: intentionally visible to one or more approved people.
- Pending approval: waiting for a user decision before any access expands.
- Helper-visible: visible to assigned operational helpers.
- Support-visible: visible only within the support relationship.
- Read-only shared: viewable by others but not editable.
- Expiring access: temporary visibility with a clear end condition.
- Urgent boundary: important notice that the product is not a substitute for emergency help.

State design rules

- Each state should have a consistent label, color behavior, icon treatment, and explanation pattern.
- States should appear inline near content, not hidden in tooltips only.
- Sensitive transitions should always include a review summary before confirming.
- Trust changes should be local and scoped, not global by accident.

Content and writing rules

Voice

The writing should be clear, plain, and warm without sounding sentimental. It should feel like a calm guide, not a brand copywriter.

Writing principles

- Use short sentences where possible.
- Prioritize clarity over cleverness.
- Name what is happening explicitly.
- Reduce ambiguity around sharing, visibility, and consequences.
- Avoid guilt-inducing copy.
- Avoid urgency unless urgency is real.

Good patterns

- “You can return to this when you are ready.”
- “This note remains private unless you choose to share it.”
- “Only this document will be shared.”
- “You can review access before sending.”

Avoid

- “Crush your to-do list.”
- “Stay on top of everything.”
- “Never miss a deadline.”
- “Let’s get productive.”
- Overly cheerful emotional language.

Core components

The MVP system should focus on reusable product patterns rather than a giant component inventory.

1. Dashboard priority card

Purpose:

Shows the single clearest next action while acknowledging surrounding context.

Required elements:

- Priority label.
- Main task title.
- Short explanation.
- Primary action.
- Secondary contextual data such as reminder timing or related shared activity.

2. Task row

Purpose:

Represents a task in a list with just enough metadata to support triage.

Required elements:

- Task title.
- Category or context.
- State badge.
- Optional due timing or helper status.
- Tap or click affordance.

3. Task detail panel

Purpose:

Explains why a task matters, what to do next, and what connected actions are available.

Required elements:

- Title.
- Reason this is suggested now.
- Suggested steps.
- Actions: complete, remind later, ask helper, or open related item.

4. Reminder module

Purpose:

Lets users choose timing and tone while previewing what they will receive.

Required elements:

- Time selector.
- Tone selector.
- Optional reason or note.
- Reminder preview.
- Save action.

5. History item

Purpose:

Creates reassurance and continuity by recording meaningful progress.

Required elements:

- Timestamp.
- Action summary.
- Optional object reference such as task or document.
- Optional privacy marker.

6. Helper role card

Purpose:

Defines the relationship and boundary for a person involved in the workflow.

Required elements:

- Person name.
- Role label.
- Capability summary.
- Access limits.
- Optional temporary state or pending state.

7. Sharing review panel

Purpose:

Explains exactly what is included or excluded before a user confirms a support request, helper delegation, or document approval.

Required elements:

- Included items.
- Excluded items.
- Audience or recipient.
- Duration if temporary.
- Primary confirm action.
- Secondary cancel or revise action.

8. Support thread item

Purpose:

Displays a message inside a bounded support conversation.

Required elements:

- Sender.
- Time.
- Message body.
- Optional system note about sharing boundaries.
- Optional reply action.

9. Document card

Purpose:

Represents a document without implying it is broadly shared.

Required elements:

- Document title.

- Current state.
- Date added or updated.
- Access summary.
- Action to review or approve.

10. Approval modal

Purpose:

Supports sensitive trust decisions in a focused context.

Required elements:

- Clear action question.
- Scope statement.
- Time limit if relevant.
- Included and excluded visibility.
- Confirm and cancel actions.

11. Settings row

Purpose:

Represents a controllable preference with low cognitive load.

Required elements:

- Setting label.
- Short explanation.
- Current value.
- Simple change action.

12. Offline reassurance block

Purpose:

Confirms what has been saved and what will happen when connection returns.

Required elements:

- Saved state confirmation.
- Waiting or sync explanation.
- Last saved change.
- Return action.

Interaction rules

Primary flow rule

Every important screen should answer three questions quickly:

- What matters now?
- What is safe to do next?
- Who can see this?

Review before share

Any flow that changes visibility should include a review step before sending or approving.

Scoped actions

Actions should affect only the relevant object whenever possible. Sharing one document should not broaden access to an entire collection. Assigning one task should not expose unrelated notes.

Re-entry support

Whenever a user returns after interruption, the product should show what was already saved and offer the least stressful next step.

Context-preserving transitions

Modals, drawers, and review panels should preserve context for sensitive actions so users feel anchored.

Canonical MVP screen map

This is the recommended screen set for the next serious design and prototype pass.

Group 1: Entry and orientation

1. Onboarding start

Purpose:

Introduces the product promise in a calm and trustworthy way.

2. Onboarding preference setup

Purpose:

Captures basic support and reminder preferences.

3. Onboarding re-entry

Purpose:

Handles unfinished onboarding with grace and clarity.

Group 2: Home and task loop

4. Home dashboard

Purpose:

Shows one primary next action, recent progress, reminders, and trust-related updates.

5. Task list

Purpose:

Allows users to scan active, deferred, and shared work.

6. Task detail

Purpose:

Explains why the task matters and offers next actions.

7. Reminder setup

Purpose:

Lets a user defer work in a supported way.

8. Completion confirmation

Purpose:

Confirms completion and transitions the task into history.

9. History and progress log

Purpose:

Shows what has already been completed or saved.

Group 3: People and collaboration

10. People overview

Purpose:

Shows who is involved and what each person can do.

11. Helper assignment flow

Purpose:

Lets a user delegate one practical task with scoped visibility.

12. Helper update review

Purpose:

Lets a user review helper activity in a bounded way.

13. Multiple helper roles overview

Purpose:

Introduces role-based collaboration patterns for more complex household dynamics.

Group 4: Support and communication

14. Support request composer

Purpose:

Lets a user ask for support while reviewing what gets shared.

15. Support sharing review

Purpose:

Confirms support message scope before send.

16. Support response thread

Purpose:

Supports ongoing back-and-forth while keeping boundaries explicit.

17. Support reply sharing review

Purpose:

Confirms what remains visible before a reply is sent.

Group 5: Documents and trust

18. Documents overview

Purpose:

Shows important files with clear visibility state.

19. Document request state

Purpose:

Surfaces when another person requests access to a specific document.

20. Document-share approval

Purpose:

Lets a user approve one document with explicit scope and expiration.

21. Document-share decline flow

Purpose:

Allows a safe no without relationship drift.

Group 6: Preferences and resilience

22. Settings overview

Purpose:

Lets users shape reminder tone, explanation style, and default privacy posture.

23. Offline or reconnect state

Purpose:

Reassures users when the system cannot sync immediately.

24. Urgent boundary state

Purpose:

Clearly states that the product does not replace emergency or crisis support.

Priority order for design production

Not every screen needs equal depth in the next pass. The canonical order for production should be:

Tier 1: Must-design now

- Home dashboard.
- Task list.
- Task detail.
- Reminder setup.
- People overview.
- Helper assignment flow.
- Support request composer.
- Support response thread.
- Documents overview.
- Document-share approval.
- Settings overview.
- Onboarding re-entry.

Tier 2: Must-design after Tier 1

- History and progress log.
- Helper update review.
- Multiple helper roles overview.
- Support reply sharing review.
- Document request state.
- Document-share decline flow.
- Offline or reconnect state.

Tier 3: Supportive or system screens

- Onboarding start.
- Onboarding preference setup.
- Completion confirmation.
- Urgent boundary state.

Open design questions

These should be resolved in the next design sprint.

1. Home emphasis

Should the dashboard focus more on the single next task, or should it balance next task, support activity, and trust requests more evenly?

2. Helper model

Should role-based sharing be the default mental model, or should the product begin with one helper and reveal role complexity later?

3. Reminder controls

How much tone customization is helpful before it becomes too much emotional labor?

4. Support boundaries

How explicit should each support-thread visibility reminder be before it becomes repetitive?

5. Document approvals

Will temporary document access feel reassuring, confusing, or burdensome to users in stressful moments?

6. Re-entry choice

When returning from unfinished onboarding, should users be sent to the dashboard first or the continuation flow first?

Immediate next deliverables

The most useful next outputs from this spec are:

1. A Figma-ready screen inventory grouped by page type and priority.
2. A component inventory with states and variants.
3. A canonical user-flow map using the approved MVP screen set.
4. A moderated usability testing guide tied to the highest-risk trust and collaboration flows.
5. A tighter coded prototype based only on the canonical screen map, not every exploratory variant.

Decision rule

If a new screen or component does not strengthen one of these outcomes, it should not be in the MVP:

- Helps the user decide what to do now.
- Helps the user safely involve someone else.
- Helps the user understand what is private versus shared.
- Helps the user resume progress after interruption.
- Helps the user feel supported while completing real logistical work.